Silver Oaks Model United Nations 2026

HISTORICAL CRISIS COMMITTEE

BACKGROUND GUIDE

AGENDA

YIHETUAN UPRISING

28TH MAY 1900

Letter from the Executive Board

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to the Historical Crisis Committee at Silver Oaks Model United Nations 2026. We as the Executive Board have compiled the essential material on this committee, its actors and its proceedings, and set it out in this document to serve as your Background Guide.

We wish to be transparent about the limitations of this document. It is a starting point for your research, not an exhaustive account of the events, actors or circumstances of North China in the summer of 1900. We reiterate that absolutely NOTHING in this document may be cited as 'proof' of any fact within the committee. Delegates are strongly encouraged to go well beyond these pages and study their portfolio, the Qing court, and the Treaty Powers in primary sources.

One note on design: the Empress Dowager Cixi is not a delegate portfolio. She holds real power at the freeze date, and the Executive Board will voice her through Imperial Edicts and court developments in Crisis Updates. How the court, the provinces, the Boxers and the Legations move her is the central contest of this committee.

We have engineered this simulation to be fast-paced, morally complex and unforgiving of half-measures. We hope this guide gives you the perspective to arrive prepared, if not to compete, then to learn.

We eagerly look forward to changing history with you.

With the warmest of regards,

Swayam – Chair

Karthika – Vice Chair

Ayush - Rapporteur

Historical Background

1) The Situation in Qing China:

- **TheQingOrder and the Tributary World :** The Qing dynasty, founded by the Manchus in 1644, ruled China through a dual system: a Manchu imperial clan and Banner aristocracy at the apex, governing through a largely Han Chinese scholar-official bureaucracy recruited by the civil-service examinations. Foreign relations were conducted on the tributary model, in which foreign rulers approached the Emperor as inferiors. By the late eighteenth century the Qing controlled the largest territory in its history, but a rapidly growing population, fiscal strain and administrative decay were already eroding central authority.

• **The Opium Wars and the Unequal Treaties :** British demands for open trade, and the opium traffic that financed it, led to the First Opium War (1839–1842). The Treaty of Nanjing (1842) ceded Hong Kong, opened five treaty ports and imposed an indemnity; supplementary treaties added extraterritoriality and most-favoured-nation clauses. The Second Opium War (1856–1860) ended with the Anglo-French occupation of Beijing, the burning of the Old Summer Palace, and the Conventions of Beijing (1860). These confirmed the Treaties of Tianjin (1858): permanent foreign legations in Beijing, more treaty ports, inland travel for foreigners, and the right of Christian missionaries to proselytise and own property in the interior.

- **Internal Rebellion and Regional Power :** Between 1850 and 1873 the Taiping, Nian and Muslim rebellions killed tens of millions. The dynasty survived only because Han provincial officials, chiefly Zeng Guofan and Li Hongzhang, raised regional armies financed by local taxes. This shifted real military and fiscal power from Beijing to the provinces, a structural fact that will decide how far any court edict in 1900 is actually obeyed.
- **Self-Strengthening and its Limits (1861–1895) :** The Zongli Yamen (1861) was created to manage foreign affairs. Reformers built arsenals, shipyards, the Beiyang Fleet, telegraphs and the first railways, while leaving Confucian institutions intact. Li Hongzhang, as Viceroy of Zhili, became the dynasty's chief modernizer and diplomat. Corruption, factionalism and divided command meant these gains were uneven.
- **The Rise of Cixi :** Empress Dowager Cixi dominated the court from 1861 as regent for two child emperors, Tongzhi and Guangxu. Guangxu assumed personal rule in 1889, but Cixi retained decisive influence over appointments, finance and the Grand Council.
- **Missionaries and the 'Religious Cases' :** Treaty protection allowed Catholic and Protestant missions to spread across North China. Converts often sought missionary backing in local lawsuits, and missionaries intervened with magistrates on their behalf. A Qing regulation of March 1899 granted Catholic bishops and priests formal equivalence

with officials, which many gentry saw as a parallel government. Disputes over property, temple land, festival levies and lawsuits (*jiao'an*) became a constant source of village violence.

- **Economic Dislocation in North China :** Imported cotton yarn and textiles undercut rural handicraft. Railway and telegraph construction displaced carters, boatmen and porters along the Grand Canal and the Beijing–Tianjin corridor. The Yellow River flooded Shandong in 1898, followed by severe drought across Shandong and Zhili in 1899–1900. Hungry, idle young men in a drought year are the social base of the movement.

2)TheEmergenceoftheYihetuan :

- **Origins in Shandong :** The movement grew out of martial-arts and spirit-possession traditions on the Shandong–Zhili border, including the Big Swords Society and the 'Spirit Boxers'. Its members practised rituals they believed made them invulnerable to blades and bullets. In 1898–1899 groups calling themselves the Yihequan ('Fists of Righteousness and Harmony') attacked Christian converts and churches.
- **Slogan and Ideology :** Their core slogan, *Fu Qing mie yang* ('Support the Qing, destroy the foreign'), made them loyal rather than anti-dynastic. They blamed foreigners and converts for drought and disorder, and targeted railways, telegraphs and foreign goods as well as people. The movement had no single leader or command structure; it spread as autonomous local units (*tan*, or altars).
- **Pingyuan and the Shift of Official Policy :** After the clash at Senluo Temple in Pingyuan county (October 1899), Governor Yuxian of Shandong treated the Boxers leniently, and the name 'Yihetuan' (Militia United in Righteousness) gained semi-official sanction. Foreign protests secured Yuxian's recall in December 1899. His successor, Yuan Shikai, suppressed the movement in Shandong, executing the leader Zhu Hongdeng, and pushed it north into Zhili.
- **Zhili, Spring 1900 :** Through spring 1900 Boxer altars multiplied across Zhili, around Baoding, Zhuozhou and Tianjin, and in the outskirts of Beijing itself. Imperial edicts wavered between condemning 'bandits' and protecting loyal 'militia'. In late May, Boxers attacked converts at Laishui, occupied Zhuozhou, and began tearing up the Beijing–Baoding railway.

3)TheCourtinCrisis,1898–1900 :

- **The Hundred Days' Reform (June–September 1898) :** The Guangxu Emperor, advised by Kang Youwei and Liang Qichao, issued edicts to reform the examinations, schools, army and administration. Many threatened Manchu and conservative interests.

- **The Coup of September 1898 :** On 21 September 1898 Cixi resumed the regency with Ronglu's backing. Guangxu was confined on the Yingtai island in the Zhongnanhai lake; six reformers were executed; Kang and Liang fled abroad under foreign protection. The Powers' sheltering of reformers, and their open sympathy for Guangxu, convinced the conservative court that foreigners were meddling in the succession.
- **The Heir Apparent Affair (January 1900) :** On 24 January 1900 Pujun, the son of Prince Duan, was named heir to the throne (*dà a-ge*). The foreign ministers pointedly declined to congratulate, which was widely read as a signal that the Powers would not accept Guangxu's deposition. Prince Duan thereby gained a personal motive to see foreign influence broken.
- **Factions at the Freeze Date :** The court is split. A war party of Manchu princes and conservative officials (Prince Duan, Prince Zhuang, Duke Lan, Gangyi, Xu Tong, Zhao Shuqiao) sees the Boxers as a loyal force that can expel the foreigners. A moderate camp (Prince Qing, Ronglu, Yuan Chang, Xu Jingcheng) and the southern viceroys (Li Hongzhang, Zhang Zhidong, Liu Kunyi) view war with all the Powers at once as suicidal.

3) Historical Wars and Crises Leading up to the Uprising :

• **The Tianjin Massacre (1870) :** Rumours that French Catholic nuns were kidnapping and mutilating Chinese children led a Tianjin crowd to kill about 20 foreigners, including the French consul and ten nuns, and dozens of Chinese converts. France threatened war; the Qing executed perpetrators, paid an indemnity and sent an apology mission. Delegates should note the template it set: anti-missionary rumour, mob violence, and a foreign demand for heads and silver. The same pattern underlies every incident of 1899–1900.

• **The Sino-French War (1884–1885) :** France fought the Qing over Vietnam. The French navy destroyed the Fujian fleet at Fuzhou, though Qing land forces won at Zhennanguan (Lang Son). The Treaty of Tianjin (1885) ended China's suzerainty over Vietnam. The war showed that Qing forces could fight well locally while losing the strategic contest.

• **The First Sino-Japanese War (1894–1895) :** The most consequential of the pre-1900 wars for this committee. Fought over control of Korea, it saw Japan destroy the Beiyang Fleet at the Yalu and Weihaiwei and overrun Li Hongzhang's Huai Army. The Treaty of Shimonoseki (April 1895), negotiated by Li, recognised Korean independence, ceded Taiwan, the Pescadores and (initially) the Liaodong Peninsula, opened further ports, permitted Japanese factories in the treaty ports, and imposed an indemnity of 200 million taels.

  - **Consequences :** The defeat discredited Self-Strengthening and Li Hongzhang personally. The indemnity forced the Qing into large foreign loans secured on Maritime Customs revenue, administered by Sir Robert Hart, mortgaging the state's most reliable income to foreign bondholders. The army was rebuilt around

new 'foreign-drill' units: Yuan Shikai's Newly Created Army and Nie Shicheng's Wuyi Army.

- **The Triple Intervention and the Russian Alliance (1895–1896) :** Russia, Germany and France forced Japan to return the Liaodong Peninsula for an extra 30 million taels. In return, Russia secured the Li–Lobanov Treaty (1896), a secret defensive alliance against Japan that allowed the Chinese Eastern Railway to cross Manchuria to Vladivostok. Xu Jingcheng later served as a Chinese director of that railway company.
- **The Juye Incident and the Scramble for Concessions (1897–1898) :** On 1 November 1897 two German Catholic missionaries were murdered at Juye, Shandong. Germany used the killings as the pretext to seize Jiaozhou Bay, obtaining a 99-year lease and railway and mining rights across Shandong (March 1898). A cascade followed within months:

Power	Concession (1898)	Region
Germany	Jiaozhou Bay lease (99 years); Shandong railway and mining rights	Shandong
Russia	Port Arthur and Dalian lease (25 years); South Manchurian rail branch	Liaodong, Manchuria
Britain	Weihaiwei lease; New Territories of Hong Kong (99 years); Yangtze sphere	Shandong, Guangdong, Yangtze valley
France	Guangzhouwan lease (99 years); sphere in the southern border provinces	Guangdong, Guangxi, Yunnan
Japan	Non-alienation pledge for Fujian	Fujian

Italy's demand for Sanmen Bay (1899) was refused by the Qing, which mobilised troops in response. That refusal persuaded the conservative court that the Powers could be resisted. In September 1899 US Secretary of State John Hay circulated the first 'Open Door' notes, asking the Powers to respect equal commercial access within their spheres. Chinese observers widely called the period *guafen*, 'the carving of the melon'.

- **The Road to 28th May 1900 :** Through January to May 1900 the diplomatic corps sent repeated joint notes demanding an edict that named and outlawed the Boxers; the court's responses remained deliberately ambiguous. Foreign warships gathered off the Dagu (Taku) bar in April as a demonstration. In mid-May Boxers killed converts at Gaoluo and Laishui. By 27 May Boxers held Zhuozhou, and Nie Shicheng's troops had clashed with them along the railway. On the freeze date, **28th May 1900**, Boxers burned the Fengtai railway junction just south-west of Beijing and its rolling stock, cutting the capital's rail link to Baoding. That evening the diplomatic corps resolved to summon legation guards from the warships off Dagu. Foreign railway engineers at Changxindian

and Baoding are isolated. Whether the court admits the guards, and whether it suppresses or embraces the Boxers, is the first decision this committee will face.

Historical Constraints

Positions below are stated as held on 28th May 1900. Delegates should verify every figure independently.

S.No.	Portfolio	Military Capability	Logistical Constraints	Economic Leverage
1	Guangxu Emperor	The nominal sovereign; every Imperial Edict is issued in his name, but he commands no troops in practice.	Confined on the Yingtai island in Zhongnanhai since the 1898 coup; his access to officials, documents and messengers is controlled by the Empress Dowager's household.	No independent purse. His leverage is legitimacy: the Powers and exiled reformers regard him as the lawful ruler, and any move to depose him carries diplomatic risk for the court.
2	Prince Duan (Zaiyi)	Commands the Hushen Ying (Tiger Spirit Division), a Manchu Banner force in the capital; father of the heir apparent Pujun.	Holds no foreign-affairs office at the freeze date; his influence runs through access to the Empress Dowager. The Boxers are not under any formal command, so he can encourage but not order them.	Draws on Imperial Clan resources and patronage; no control over the treasury or customs revenue.
3	Prince Qing (Yikuang)	No field command; presides over the Zongli Yamen, the Qing foreign office.	Must carry every concession to the Legations through a court increasingly hostile to them; risks being replaced at the Yamen by the war party.	The principal official channel for any negotiation on guards, indemnities or protection of foreigners; well connected to foreign legations and banks.

S.No.	Portfolio	Military Capability	Logistical Constraints	Economic Leverage
4	Ronglu	Grand Councillor and Grand Secretary; commander-in-chief of the Wuwei (Guards) Army, with nominal authority over the divisions of Nie Shicheng, Dong Fuxiang and Song Qing, and direct command of the Centre Division near Beijing.	Nominal authority is not real control: Dong Fuxiang answers to the Manchu princes, and Nie is in the field near Tianjin. Cannot openly oppose the Empress Dowager without losing her trust.	Oversees pay and supply for the Guards Army; control over arms depots and ammunition issue is a quiet but decisive lever.
5	Gangyi	No troops of his own; as Grand Councillor he can be sent as an imperial commissioner to Boxer districts to report and advise.	His assessments reach the throne directly, but he depends on what local officials and Boxer leaders show him.	Known for his 1899 revenue-raising tour of the southern provinces; experienced at extracting funds for the court.
6	Prince Zhuang (Zaixun)	Commandant of the Peking Gendarmerie, which a field army; disciplines the capital and controls its gates.	His forces are a police and garrison body, not a field army; position inside Beijing depends on whether he chooses to.	Controls entry and movement within the capital; no fiscal authority.
7	Duke Lan (Zailan)	Brother of Prince Duan; a senior Banner officer in the capital's garrison establishment.	No independent command; acts in concert with Prince Duan and Prince Zhuang.	No fiscal authority; influence lies in clan standing and access to Banner units in the city.
8	Xu Tong	No military role; Grand Secretary and	Elderly and fiercely anti-foreign; his influence is ideological	No fiscal authority; leverage lies in his standing among conservative literati

S.No.	Portfolio	Military Capability	Logistical Constraints	Economic Leverage
		tutor to the heir apparent.	and personal rather than administrative.	and his closeness to the heir apparent's household.
9	Zhao Shuqiao	Grand Councillor and President of the Board of Punishments; no field troops.	Must reconcile his legal responsibility for public order with the court's reluctance to prosecute Boxers.	Controls the judicial machinery that can declare the Boxers bandits or loyal militia, and that tries officials.
10	Yuan Chang	No troops; a minister of the Zongli Yamen.	A Han official dependent on rank and access; openly opposing the war party exposes him to impeachment and worse.	No fiscal role; leverage is expertise in foreign affairs and the ability to memorialise the throne.
11	Xu Jingcheng	No troops; a minister of the Zongli Yamen and former envoy to Russia and Germany, with a directorship of the Chinese Eastern Railway.	Same exposure as Yuan Chang; his foreign experience makes him suspect to the war party.	Personal contacts with St Petersburg and Berlin, and knowledge of Russian railway interests in Manchuria.
12	Dong Fuxiang	Commands the Gansu Braves (Rear Division of the Wuwei Army), roughly 10,000 Muslim and Han troops stationed in the capital region.	Poorly disciplined and indifferently armed relative to the Wuyi Army; loyal to the Manchu princes more than to Ronglu. Infamous for assaults on foreigners on the railway in 1898.	No fiscal role; depends on Ronglu and the Board of Revenue for pay and ammunition.
13	Li Hongzhang	Acting Viceroy of Liangguang at	Roughly 2,000 km from Beijing, aged 77, and	Controls Guangdong revenue and trade at

S.No.	Portfolio	Military Capability	Logistical Constraints	Economic Leverage
		Canton, commanding provincial forces in Guangdong and Guangxi.	discredited at court since 1895; his forces cannot reach the north quickly.	Canton; enjoys the confidence of foreign governments, which makes him the natural negotiator of any settlement.
14	Zhang Zhidong	Viceroy of Huguang at Wuchang; commands new-style provincial troops and the Hanyang Arsenal.	Distant from the northern front; must protect a middle-Yangtze region full of foreign trade and missions.	Controls the Hanyang Ironworks and Arsenal and Hubei revenue; key stakeholder in the Beijing–Hankou railway.
15	Liu Kunyi	Viceroy of Liangjiang at Nanjing; commands lower Yangtze forces and oversees the Jiangnan Arsenal.	His region is Britain's declared sphere; any anti-foreign rising there would invite immediate intervention.	Controls the richest provinces in the empire and Shanghai's trade revenues.
16	Yuan Shikai	Acting Governor of Shandong, commanding the Newly Created Army, the best-trained modern force in the empire.	Shares a province with the German leasehold at Jiaozhou; deploying north would expose Shandong to Boxer revival and German retaliation.	Controls Shandong provincial revenue; cultivates careful relations with German railway and mining interests.
17	Yuxian	Governor of Shanxi since March 1900, commanding provincial forces there.	Shanxi is landlocked and far from foreign gunboats, giving him freedom of action but little reach toward Beijing.	Shanxi's remittance banks (*piaohao*) handle much of the empire's inter-provincial finance and official remittances.
18	Yulu	Viceroy of Zhili and Commissioner of the Northern Ports	Caught between edicts that protect the Boxers and foreign consuls in	Controls Zhili revenue and the Tianjin customs station.

S.No.	Portfolio	Military Capability	Logistical Constraints	Economic Leverage
		at Tianjin; formal authority over provincial forces and the Dagu forts.	Tianjin demanding their suppression; Boxer altars are multiplying inside his own city.	
19	Nie Shicheng	Commands the Wuyi Army (Front Division of the Wuwei Army), German-trained troops with modern rifles and artillery, deployed along the Beijing–Tianjin corridor.	Ordered to protect the railways but not to provoke the Boxers; his troops are hated by them and distrusted by the war party.	No fiscal role; dependent on Ronglu and Yulu for supply.
20	Sheng Xuanhuai	No troops; Director-General of the Imperial Railways and head of the Imperial Telegraph Administration, based in Shanghai.	His lines in the north are being cut by Boxers; he cannot protect them physically.	Controls the telegraph network that carries edicts, viceregal correspondence and foreign cables, plus the China Merchants' Steam Navigation Co. and the Imperial Bank of China. Information itself is his leverage.
21	Cao Futian	Leads several thousand Boxers from Jinghai county, moving on Tianjin.	No firearms to speak of beyond swords and spears; no supply system beyond levies on villages and converts' property.	Leverage is mass: control of the streets and the ability to destroy railway, telegraph and foreign property.
22	Zhang Decheng	Leads the Boxer altar from Duliu, south of Tianjin, among the largest	Same lack of arms and logistics; relations with other Boxer leaders are rivalrous rather than coordinated.	Commandeers local resources; can extract 'contributions' from merchants and officials.

S.No.	Portfolio	Military Capability	Logistical Constraints	Economic Leverage
		single Boxer bands in Zhili.		
23	Lin Hei'er	Leads the Red Lanterns (*Hongdengzhao*), the female wing of the movement in Tianjin, revered as the 'Holy Mother of the Yellow Lotus'.	No combat role in the conventional sense; operates through ritual, morale, rumour and nursing.	Her leverage is spiritual authority over Boxers and the Tianjin populace, and the ability to shape rumour.
24	Sir Claude MacDonald	British Minister in Beijing; former army officer; can request guards and landing parties from the Royal Navy at Dagu.	The British legation compound is the largest in the Quarter but undefended at freeze date; any guards must come 120 km by rail from Tianjin.	Britain holds the largest share of China's foreign trade and the Yangtze sphere; British bondholders hold much of the Qing debt.
25	Baron Clemens von Ketteler	German Minister; can call on the German East Asia Squadron and the garrison at Jiaozhou.	The German legation sits on Legation Street near the Hatamen gate, exposed; his famously aggressive manner is itself a constraint.	Leverage via German interests in Shandong railways and mines, and Berlin's readiness to exploit any incident as in 1897.
26	Stéphen Pichon	French Minister; can call on the French Far East squadron and troops in Indochina.	France is the official protector of Catholic missions, so every attack on Catholic converts lands on his desk.	Leverage through the Catholic missions and the French sphere in South China; French capital in the Beijing–Hankou railway.
27	Edwin Conger	US Minister; can call on the US Asiatic Squadron and troops in the Philippines.	American forces are committed to the Philippine–American War; 1900 is a presidential election	Leverage via the Open Door policy, American trade and the large American Protestant

S.No.	Portfolio	Military Capability	Logistical Constraints	Economic Leverage
			year, and Washington avoids alliances.	missions in North China.
28	Mikhail de Giers	Russian Minister; Russia has the largest forces near North China, in Port Arthur and Manchuria.	Must balance protecting legations against St Petersburg's preference to appear as China's friend while securing Manchuria.	Leverage via the Chinese Eastern Railway, the Russo-Chinese Bank and the 1896 alliance.
29	Nishi Tokujirō	Japanese Minister and former Foreign Minister; Japan has the nearest large army and transport capacity.	Tokyo is wary of being cast as the aggressor after the Triple Intervention, and of Russian moves in Korea and Manchuria.	Leverage via Japanese trade, the Shimonoseki indemnity, and Japan's ability to put troops ashore faster than any European power.
30	Marquis Giuseppe Salvago Raggi	Italian Minister; a small naval contingent off Dagu.	Italy's forces in the region are minimal; the Sanmen Bay rebuff of 1899 weakens Italian credibility with the Qing.	Limited economic stake; leverage lies in joint action with the other Powers.
31	Arthur von Rosthorn	Austro-Hungarian chargé d'affaires; can request sailors from Austro-Hungarian cruisers in Chinese waters.	The smallest of the Legations' contingents; dependent on cooperation with Germany and the others.	Minimal direct trade; leverage lies in Rosthorn's experience in the Chinese Customs and his knowledge of Qing administration.
32	Vice Admiral Sir Edward Seymour	Commander-in-Chief, Royal Navy China Station; senior naval officer off Dagu, able to land a naval brigade.	Naval landing parties are not equipped for a long inland march; the Hai (Peiho) River is shallow, and the railway to Beijing is under attack.	No fiscal role; his leverage is the ability to act first with the most ships on station.

S.No.	Portfolio	Military Capability	Logistical Constraints	Economic Leverage
33	Admiral Yevgeni Alekseyev	Governor of the Kwantung Leased Territory and Commander of the Russian Pacific Squadron at Port Arthur, with a substantial garrison.	Must protect the Chinese Eastern Railway across Manchuria as well as respond in Zhili; troops sent south weaken Manchuria.	Controls the Port Arthur base and naval resources; Russian railway investment in Manchuria is the asset he must defend.
34	Sir Robert Hart	Inspector-General of Lives in Beijing beside the Imperial Maritime Customs; no troops, though Customs staff could be armed in an emergency.	the Legation Quarter; his staff and records are exposed.	Controls the customs revenue that services the Qing's foreign loans and indemnities, and runs the Imperial Post. Arguably the single most important financial actor in the empire.
35	Bishop Alphonse Favier	Vicar Apostolic of Northern Zhili, based at the Beitang (North Cathedral) inside the Imperial City; no troops, but thousands of converts look to him.	The Beitang is isolated from the Legation Quarter; any defence depends on a few marines and converts.	Leverage through the Catholic mission network, which supplies intelligence from the countryside, and through French diplomatic protection. Historically warned Pichon of a planned attack in a letter of 19 May 1900.
36	George Ernest Morrison	Correspondent of *The Times* in Beijing; no military role.	Depends on the telegraph to file; once lines are cut, his voice falls silent.	Leverage is publicity: his reports shape British and international opinion and pressure foreign governments to act.

The Physical Battlespace

1) Geographical Significance :

- **TheNorth China Plain and Zhili Province :** Zhili surrounds the capital and is a flat, densely farmed alluvial plain cut by rivers and canals. Walled county towns and villages lie a few kilometres apart, giving Boxer altars dense recruiting ground and cover. The plain has few natural obstacles, but summer rains turn its dirt roads to mud, so movement depends on the railway, the rivers and the Grand Canal.
- **Beijing :** The capital is a city of walls within walls. The **Inner (Tartar) City** to the north, roughly 6.5 km by 5 km, encloses the **Imperial City** and, at its heart, the **Forbidden City**. The **Outer (Chinese) City** adjoins it to the south. The massive Tartar Wall, about 12 m high and wide enough to drive carts along its top, separates the two and overlooks everything near it.
- **The Legation Quarter :** The eleven foreign legations cluster along Legation Street (Dongjiaomin Xiang) in the south-east of the Inner City, directly beneath the Tartar Wall and just east of the Imperial City. The quarter is an open neighbourhood, not a fortress: it shares streets with Chinese shops, homes and the Hanlin Academy, and has no defensive perimeter at the freeze date. Whoever holds the stretch of Tartar Wall above it commands the Legations. The Russian and American legations lie closest to the wall; the British legation is the largest compound, with its own wells.

- **The Beitang (North Cathedral) :** Bishop Favier's cathedral and mission compound lie inside the Imperial City, about 3 km north-west of the Legation Quarter and separated from it by the palace precincts. It shelters orphanages, schools and thousands of converts, and would have to be defended on its own.
- **The Beijing–Tianjin Corridor :** The railway runs roughly 130 km from the Majiapu terminus outside the Outer City, through Fengtai junction, Langfang and Yangcun, to Tianjin. The Hai (Peiho) River runs roughly parallel, navigable by junks and lighters to Tongzhou but shallow and winding. Fengtai, burned on the freeze date, is the junction where the Beijing–Baoding line branches south-west; its loss already isolates Baoding and the engineers on that line.
- **Tianjin :** The commercial capital of the north and seat of the Zhili Viceroy. The foreign concessions (British, French, German, and others) lie along the river south-east of the walled Chinese city, with the railway station across the river. Tianjin is the staging point for any foreign force moving on Beijing, and also the centre of Boxer and Red Lantern activity.
- **The Dagu (Taku) Forts :** Four earthwork forts guard the mouth of the Hai River, about 65 km downstream of Tianjin. A sand bar keeps large foreign warships far offshore; only

gunboats and shallow-draught vessels can cross it. Control of the forts decides whether foreign reinforcements can reach Tianjin by river and rail.

- **The Provinces Beyond :** Shandong (Yuan Shikai, with Germany at Jiaozhou), Shanxi (Yuxian, landlocked and isolated), Manchuria (the Chinese Eastern Railway and Russia), and the Yangtze provinces (the three viceroys and the main foreign trade) each form a theatre of its own. Delegates should consider that a war in Zhili need not become a war across the empire, and that the viceroys know this.

2) Climate and Seasonal Conditions

- **Drought :** North China has endured severe drought through 1899 and the spring of 1900. Crops have failed, prices are high, and idle young men have time on their hands. Boxer propaganda claims the rains will return once the foreigners are expelled. If rain falls, recruitment may slacken; if it does not, it will swell.
- **Heat and dust :** Late May and June bring rising heat, regularly above 35°C on the plain, and dust storms from the north-west. Heat degrades the endurance of marching columns, especially naval landing parties unaccustomed to long inland marches.
- **The summer rains :** The rainy season normally arrives in July and August. Rains would swell the Hai River, aiding river transport, but turn the plain to mud and flood low-lying ground.
- **Communications :** The telegraph is the nervous system of every actor in this committee. Edicts to the provinces, viceregal correspondence, legation cables and *The Times* despatches all depend on lines that Boxers are already cutting. Once lines are cut, messengers on horseback take days to cover the same distance.

3) Forces and Doctrines

- **The Qing Military :** The Qing army is a layered and uneven institution. The old Banner and Green Standard forces are poorly trained and often under-strength. The provincial 'braves' raised since the Taiping era vary widely. The new Wuwei (Guards) Army, organised under Ronglu in 1899, contains the empire's best units: Nie Shicheng's German-trained Front Division, Yuan Shikai's modern Right Division (now in Shandong), Song Qing's Left Division, Dong Fuxiang's Rear Division and Ronglu's own Centre Division. These forces are well armed with modern rifles and artillery, but they answer to different patrons and have never fought as one.
- **The Yihetuan :** The Boxers fight in loosely coordinated bands under altar leaders, armed mostly with swords, spears and few firearms. Their doctrine is ritual: possession by deities and invulnerability charms give them extraordinary courage in assaults, but also catastrophic casualties against magazine rifles and machine guns. Their real strength lies in numbers, local support, and the ability to destroy railways, telegraphs, churches and isolated foreign or convert communities.
- **The Treaty Powers :** At the freeze date the Powers have only warships off Dagu, small consular guards, and the promise of detachments landed from their ships. Each Power

answers to its own capital, and no unified command exists. Their tactical advantage is firepower (magazine rifles, Maxim and Colt machine guns, naval guns); their weaknesses are small numbers, distance from the sea, and mutual suspicion over who will gain the most from intervention.

• **The Southern Viceroys :** Li Hongzhang, Zhang Zhidong and Liu Kunyi control the empire's richest provinces and most modern arsenals. Delegates should note that whether these men obey the court in a war, or quietly negotiate their own neutrality with the foreign consuls, is not settled at the freeze date.

Portfolio Influence

S.No.	Portfolio	Sphere of Influence	Role in the Committee
1	Guangxu Emperor	The formal source of all Imperial authority; the figure the Powers and reformers recognise as legitimate.	The committee's most constrained head of state. Expected to find ways to act through intermediaries, signal to moderates and foreigners, and resist being made irrelevant, without provoking his own deposition.
2	Prince Duan (Zaiyi)	Leader of the Manchu war party; father of the heir apparent.	The committee's driving hawk. Expected to push the court toward embracing the Boxers and confronting the Legations, and to turn the succession question into leverage.
3	Prince Qing (Yikuang)	The Zongli Yamen and the official foreign-relations channel.	The committee's chief court moderate. Expected to keep a negotiating channel to the Legations open while surviving pressure from the war party to hand over the Yamen.
4	Ronglu	Command of the Guards Army; trusted counsellor of the Empress Dowager.	The pivotal swing vote. Expected to decide in practice how hard Qing troops press or protect the foreigners, while never visibly defying the throne.
5	Gangyi	Grand Council deliberations and imperial	A senior hawk whose reports shape the court's view of the Boxers. Expected to argue that the Boxers are loyal and effective, and to push for their incorporation as militia.

S.No.	Portfolio	Sphere of Influence	Role in the Committee
		commissions of inquiry.	
6	Prince Zhuang (Zaixun)	Policing and gate control in Beijing.	Controls what happens on the capital's streets. Expected to decide whether Boxers enter and operate freely in Beijing, and how the capital's security forces treat foreigners and converts.
7	Duke Lan (Zailan)	Banner forces and clan politics alongside Prince Duan.	An amplifier of the war party. Expected to coordinate closely with Prince Duan and Prince Zhuang and to press for action within the capital.
8	Xu Tong	Conservative literati opinion; the heir apparent's household.	The ideological voice of the court's anti-foreign wing. Expected to frame the crisis in terms of orthodoxy and dynastic honour, and to oppose every concession.
9	Zhao Shuqiao	The Board of Punishments and the legal status of the Boxers.	The legal arbiter. Expected to decide how the Boxers are classified in law, and to face the consequences either way: with the court if he condemns them, with the Powers if he does not.
10	Yuan Chang	Zongli Yamen deliberations and memorials to the throne.	A voice of caution with personal risk attached. Expected to argue against war in memorials and court debate, knowing the war party may destroy him for it.
11	Xu Jingcheng	Zongli Yamen deliberations; relations with Russia and Germany.	The court's best-informed foreign specialist. Expected to warn the court of the Powers' real capabilities and to explore separate understandings, especially with Russia.
12	Dong Fuxiang	The Gansu Braves in and around the capital.	The committee's most dangerous armed actor inside Beijing. Expected to decide how his troops treat the Legations and the Boxers, with orders from Ronglu and the princes that may contradict each other.
13	Li Hongzhang	Guangdong and Guangxi; the	The committee's senior statesman and eventual negotiator. Expected to keep the south out of

S.No.	Portfolio	Sphere of Influence	Role in the Committee
		empire's most experienced diplomat.	war, maintain foreign trust, and position himself for any settlement.
14	Zhang Zhidong	Hubei and Hunan; the Hanyang industrial base.	A pillar of the southern bloc. Expected to protect the middle Yangtze from both Boxers and foreign intervention, and to decide how literally to obey edicts from the north.
15	Liu Kunyi	Jiangsu, Anhui, Jiangxi; Nanjing and the Shanghai hinterland.	The other pillar of the southern bloc. Expected to manage relations with British and other consuls in Shanghai and to shape any regional arrangement for keeping the peace.
16	Yuan Shikai	Shandong and its modern army.	The committee's most capable Qing general. Expected to choose between suppressing the Boxers, sending troops north, or preserving his army, and to manage the German presence on his doorstep.
17	Yuxian	Shanxi.	The patron of the Boxers in office. Expected to determine whether Shanxi becomes a refuge for the movement, and how missionaries and converts in his province are treated.
18	Yulu	Zhili, Tianjin and the Dagu forts.	The frontline Qing governor. Expected to manage Tianjin's foreign concessions, Boxer altars in his own city, and any foreign demand concerning the Dagu forts.
19	Nie Shicheng	The Wuyi Army along the Beijing–Tianjin corridor.	The committee's frontline Qing commander. Expected to make real-time choices about protecting railways, fighting Boxers or fighting foreigners, under conflicting orders.
20	Sheng Xuanhuai	Railways, telegraphs, shipping and banking; based in Shanghai.	The committee's information broker. Expected to decide what messages move, how fast, and to whom, and to use that position to broker understandings between the viceroys and the foreign consuls.

S.No.	Portfolio	Sphere of Influence	Role in the Committee
21	Cao Futian	Boxer bands of the Jinghai–Tianjin area.	A grassroots military leader. Expected to direct attacks on railways, missions and concessions and to compete with other leaders for prestige and recognition by the court.
22	Zhang Decheng	The Duliu altar and its followers.	The largest independent Boxer force near Tianjin. Expected to bargain with officials for recognition and supplies, and to decide where Boxer strength is committed.
23	Lin Hei'er	The Red Lanterns and popular belief in Tianjin.	The movement's spiritual figurehead. Expected to shape morale, rumour and the movement's sense of divine mission, and to contest any attempt by officials to co-opt or disband it.
24	Sir Claude MacDonald	British policy in Beijing; the largest legation.	The committee's de facto leader of the diplomatic corps in practice. Expected to coordinate the Legations' response, summon guards, and weigh British interests in the Yangtze against the danger in the north.
25	Baron Clemens von Ketteler	German policy in Beijing; the Jiaozhou garrison.	The committee's most confrontational diplomat. Expected to push for forceful demands on the court, with the risk that his own conduct escalates the crisis.
26	Stéphen Pichon	French policy and protection of Catholic missions.	The voice of the missions within the diplomatic corps. Expected to press for protection of converts and the Beitang, and to coordinate with Favier.
27	Edwin Conger	American policy in Beijing; American Protestant missions.	The Open Door advocate. Expected to seek protection of Americans without entangling alliances, and to argue for preserving China's integrity against partition.
28	Mikhail de Giers	Russian policy in Beijing.	The Power most able to act alone. Expected to balance joint action with the Legations against Russia's own ambitions in Manchuria and its claim to be China's friend.

S.No.	Portfolio	Sphere of Influence	Role in the Committee
29	Nishi Tokujirō	Japanese policy in Beijing.	The Asian Power among the Western ones. Expected to prove Japan a reliable partner of the Powers while watching Russia closely.
30	Marquis Giuseppe Salvago Raggi	Italian policy in Beijing.	A minor Power seeking standing. Expected to secure a seat at every joint decision and to restore Italian prestige after Sanmen Bay.
31	Arthur von Rosthorn	Austro-Hungarian policy in Beijing.	The smallest legation with the deepest Chinese expertise. Expected to provide informed judgment to the diplomatic corps and to make the most of a tiny contingent.
32	Vice Admiral Sir Edward Seymour	The Royal Navy off Dagu and any naval brigade it lands.	The committee's first responder. Expected to decide when, how and by which route a relief force moves inland, and to coordinate the other national squadrons.
33	Admiral Yevgeni Alekseyev	Port Arthur and the Russian Pacific Squadron.	The reserve of force on the Russian side. Expected to decide how many troops to send to Zhili and how many to hold for Manchuria.
34	Sir Robert Hart	The Maritime Customs, the Imperial Post and the Qing loan system.	A servant of the Qing trusted by the Powers. Expected to advise both sides, protect the customs revenue on which every settlement will depend, and warn of the consequences of war.
35	Bishop Alphonse Favier	The Catholic missions of Northern Zhili and the Beitang.	The committee's early-warning voice and defender of converts. Expected to press for protection of the Beitang and outlying missions and to feed intelligence from the countryside to the Legations.
36	George Ernest Morrison	*The Times* and international public opinion.	The committee's press. Expected to issue reports that shape how foreign capitals and publics understand the crisis, and to test every actor's public statements against what he sees.

Rules of Procedure

Given the conventionality of the UNA-USA RoP, the Executive Board has chosen not to adhere to it, and instead adopts the following procedure unique to this committee:

- **Open Debate :** The moderated floor session at the start of each cycle, in which delegates speak in Chair-recognised order or by independent participation, to respond to the latest update, state their position and signal intentions. Consultations are of two types:
  - **Formal Consultations :** Structured, Executive Board-recognised discussions with no set individual speaking time; the total duration is at the Executive Board's discretion.
  - **Informal Consultations :** Unstructured discussions requiring no recognition, with no set individual speaking time; the total duration is at the Executive Board's discretion.
- **Unmod :** An informal break from structured speaking, in which delegates may leave their seats, speak to one another directly and privately, research, and draft their submissions. Three actions are permitted:
  - **Lobbying :** Approaching other delegates to build support for a shared position or plan, and to form Blocs.
  - **Research :** Consulting this Background Guide, reference material or contemporary records.
  - **Drafting :** Writing Directives, Communiques, Press Releases, Memorials or Portfolio Requests, individually or jointly with a Bloc, in the formats below.

What are Directives? : A Directive is a formal written order issued by a Portfolio, requesting that a specific action be taken using the resources and authority that Portfolio actually holds. It is the main way delegates cause change in the crisis. The EB reads every Directive, decides whether it is realistic given the Portfolio's actual powers, and reports the outcome in the next Crisis Update.

What are Communiques? : A formal communication from a Portfolio in committee to an actor NOT present in committee, to request an action or negotiate terms (for example, a foreign minister cabling his capital, or a viceroy writing to a foreign consul).

What are Press Releases? : A public statement intended for the general public or the press, used to shape opinion or make an official position known. In 1900 this includes proclamations, placards and notices to newspapers.

What are Memorials? : A formal written submission from a Qing official to the throne, recommending a course of action. Because the Empress Dowager is not a delegate, Memorials are the means by which Qing portfolios seek Imperial Edicts. The EB will respond to Memorials

through Edicts announced in Crisis Updates. Edicts may be ambiguous, contradictory or contrary to the Memorial submitted, exactly as they were historically.

What are Portfolio Requests? : A private message sent directly to the Executive Board asking a clarifying question about the resources or information a Portfolio has access to.

1) Formats :

COMMUNIQUE / PRESS RELEASE / MEMORIAL / PORTFOLIO REQUEST FORMAT

- Title : (Communique / Press Release / Memorial / Portfolio Request)
- From : (Name of Portfolio)
- To : Executive Board (the individual addressed, in the case of a Communique; 'The Throne' in the case of a Memorial)
- Content : The full text of the statement, message or question

2)DirectiveFormat :

- **From :** (Name of Portfolio/s)
- **To :** Head of State / Relevant Department or Command
- **Type :** Solo / Joint
- **Covert Operation / Overt Operation**
- **Primary Objective :** The primary objective of the Directive
- **Secondary Objective** (not compulsory) : A secondary objective of the Directive
- **Mission Brief :** A 4–5 line summary of the plan of action
- **Plan of Action :** The complete plan, covering why, what, when, where and how
- **Additional Information** (not compulsory) : Supporting material such as maps, diagrams or statistics that the EB should consider

3) Key Terms :

- **Line of Communication :** The LOC is the formal submission window that follows Unmod. Its duration is announced by the Executive Board at the start of each cycle and may vary. All written material for the cycle is submitted during this window. Nothing is accepted once it closes; late submissions wait for the next cycle.
- **Telegraph Disruption :** Communication speed is part of the simulation. Where telegraph lines are cut, the EB may delay or withhold the delivery of Communiques between distant actors (for example, between Beijing and Canton), and will say so in the Crisis Update.

- **Crisis Updates :** Once the LOC closes, the Executive Board works out the consequences of the submissions received and delivers a Crisis Update at the start of the next Open Debate. A Crisis Update typically covers:
    - o The outcome of Directives: success, partial success, failure or an unexpected result.
    - o Imperial Edicts issued in response to Memorials or on the court's own initiative.
    - o Public Press Releases and Communiques, and how other parties have reacted.
    - o New developments in the crisis, introduced by the EB to keep the situation moving.
    - o Some information may go to the whole committee; other information may be passed privately to the Portfolio(s) concerned.

AND THE CYCLE CONTINUES.

Citations

1)Primary Sources

- UK Parliamentary Papers — *China No. 3 (1900): Correspondence respecting the Insurrectionary Movement in China* (Cd. 257), presented July 1900; covers MacDonald's despatches through spring 1900 : archive.org
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- UK Parliamentary Papers — *China No. 7 (1901): Correspondence respecting the Imperial Railway of North China* : archive.org
- U.S. Department of State — *Foreign Relations of the United States, 1901, Appendix: Affairs in China* (Rockhill Report, negotiations of the Powers with China) : history.state.gov
- U.S. War Department — *Reports on Military Operations in South Africa and China* (July 1901) : archive.org

2)Recommended Scholarship (no links; available through libraries)

- Joseph W. Esherick, *The Origins of the Boxer Uprising* (University of California Press, 1987) — the standard account of the movement's social roots in Shandong.
- Paul A. Cohen, *History in Three Keys: The Boxers as Event, Experience, and Myth* (Columbia University Press, 1997) — essential on Boxer beliefs, drought and the Red Lanterns.
- Lanxin Xiang, *The Origins of the Boxer War: A Multinational Study* (Routledge, 2003) — court politics and the decision for war.

- Peter Fleming, *The Siege at Peking* (1959) — a narrative of the Legations' experience.
- Robert Bickers and R. G. Tiedemann (eds.), *The Boxers, China, and the World* (Rowman & Littlefield, 2007).
- Sir Robert Hart, *'These from the Land of Sinim': Essays on the Chinese Question* (1901) — Hart's own contemporary reflections.

Delegates should treat secondary accounts critically and prefer contemporary documents wherever possible, particularly for statements of what was known on 28th May 1900.

